



## AFTER

The Civil War was one of the most significant events in the movement toward female equality in the United States. As men marched off to war, women took their places in factories, fields, and stores.

### WOMEN'S ROLES EXPAND

In North and South alike, women's activities in ladies' aid societies, and as nurses in national organizations, gained them recognition as integral contributors to the war effort. In so doing, they **expanded what was regarded as "respectable" women's work**.

Spared invasion and occupation, Northern women benefited the most from the war and **reignited the women's rights movement in the postwar decades**. Southern women, often devastated by the loss of property and deaths of family members, were less likely to profit socially but **became hardened to privations**. One woman in Warrenton, Virginia, wrote: "We keep true to the South amid all our sore trials—and at times are to be pitied." Despite this, their experiences operating farms and plantations in their husbands' absence and witnessing war firsthand helped to **crack the gender barriers of the old South**.